

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*When Things Fall Apart ~ Heart Advice for Difficult Times
It's Never Too Late - How to...be untroubled*

July 27th, 2025



"The Orange Trees"
By Gustave Caillebotte, 1878

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Abraham Ross, Guest Organist

Pari intervallo — Arvo Pärt

Chorale prelude: "Drop, drop slow tears" - Vincent Persichetti

Chant des fleurs - Jean-Louis Florenz

Burgeoning - Robyn Jacob

-Dr. Abraham Ross, Guest Organist

Niagara - Jonathan Dove

-Carolyn Hoff, N.E.O. Festival Organ Fellow

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Words of Gathering

Emily Kang & Lulu Gregoropoulos

Wild and Wondrous God,

Creator of all

Spirit of Life and love and liberation

Mother and Father and Conspirator and Friend and Lover of Our Souls

Tender tender of possibility and dream,

You have called us together, in this time, and in this place

and so, here we are:

full of wisdom and wondering

full of hope and fear

weariness and longing

passion and pain.

Unleash your wild power in us, we pray

Deepen our connection with You and with each other

Deepen our capacity to hear the voices of those too often silenced,

to honor the presence of those too often erased,

to center the wisdoms of those too often pushed to the margins,

that we might bear witness to the complex truths of our wholly holy lives

and the complex needs of your beautiful, broken world.

In this time of worship, let our hearts, our minds, and our bodies

be open to all that is around us, among us, and within us. [adapt/enfleshed]

May it be so.

May it be so for all of us!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

From Wisdom Emerging

ST DENIO

From Wisdom emerging, we fashion a space
For people converging in safety and grace,
To shelter the freedom of one and of all
In Love without border or boundary or wall.

Faith's journey reclaiming, we blaze a new trail
With others, exclaiming: "Let justice prevail!"
Rejecting worn paths that oppress and mislead,
We walk in community, cherished and freed!

Forever exploring, we seek to learn more
Of Wisdom's outpouring, of Love's open door.
Amazed at the mysteries and graces we find,
We joyfully share them with all humankind.

The future progressing, we move through its change,
Old systems redressing, new patterns arrange;
Protecting all the freedoms with every new choice,
We follow the Spirit and raise our clear voice!

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Eternal God, today we remember those who have brought us to this place,
who have labored with You
who have labored for us
to make a way out of no way
dreaming dreams and visioning visions
both ancient and new.

We give thanks for that great cloud of witnesses
those who whisper their wisdom in stories, songs, and poems
those who gave birth to movement
and moments
of liberation
of healing
of justice
of love.

On this day, may we remember and honor the legacies of resistance
to evil, injustice, and oppression
that have empowered our being
and invited our becoming.

[adapt/enfleshed]

***For this, and so much more,
we give thanks.
Amen and Amen!***

***Introit**

"Clotho's Litany"
Mariah Rae, *Soloist*

ZEKE MORGAN

***The Lord's Prayer**

Emily Kang & Lulu Gregoropoulos

[Our Father / Mother / Creator / God]

*Our God...who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.*

*Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Inspired by the hands of hope
working, healing, holding, sustaining,
we have gathered this day to embrace
the task that is ours.

*May our hearts
be strong for the work we find.*

May our minds
be open to the challenges
it will provide us.

*May our bodies
be ready when the call comes
so that no one is ever
left behind.*

On this promise we stand
as those who see this world too clearly
and yet would see it
no other way.

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Mark, Chapter 14

Emily Kang & Lulu Gregoropoulos

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of justice and mercy,
in these days we acknowledge that freedom is a constant struggle,
and the labor is hard
but it is holy, too, and there is joy to be found in the laboring together.

Your healing salve of grace spills over, it overflows,
and it cannot be controlled or contained.

Your Gospel is indeed Good News
and your story brings the powerful down from their thrones
and lifts up the lowly.

Help us to remember your story is our story
and the story is still being written
as we work, together.

So this morning, Come Spirit, Come.
Convict us with curiosity.
Convert us from complacency.
Consecrate us with compassion.
Conspire with us, as we lean into the New Life
emerging from the destruction around us.

Show us now, and in the days to come,
what we need to lay down
set aside
offer up
and divest from
in order for us all to be free.

Then, O God, help us to return to what matters most:
Seeking justice
practicing kindness
deepening into solidarity
with each other

with you
within the entangled, interconnected web of holy life
in which we live
and move
and have our being.
[adapt/enfleshed]

May it be so.
May we make it so.
Amen!

Meditation Anthem

“Connection”

JAMEY GUZMAN

N.E.O. Festival Chorus and Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

Message

How to...be untroubled

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

God,
When I am famished,
Give me someone who needs food;
When I am thirsty,
Send me someone who needs water;
When I am cold,
Send me someone to warm;
When I am hurting,
Send me someone to console;
When I am poor,
Lead someone needy to me;
When I have no time,
Give me someone to help for a moment;
Give me someone to praise;
When I am discouraged,
Send me someone to encourage;
When I need another's understanding,
Give me someone who needs mine;
When I need somebody to take care of me,

*Send me someone to care for;
When I think too much of myself,
Turn my thoughts toward someone else.*

-Anonymous, twentieth century, Japan

We ask God to help us in this time,
to open our minds and prepare our lives -
as we learn to give so that generosity
will come to live in our hearts,
and justice will come among us
in our community, and in our world.

Offertory

"Simply Assisting God"
N.E.O. Festival Chorus & Cathedral Choir

SAM SCHEIBE

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Mystery of God
heartbeat of the universe,
center of spirited change and rebirth;
we glorify your ways:
the ways of dignity and justice,
the ways of love for all creatures,
the ways of caring for the earth.

Let us be simple in our needs,
showing compassion for our neighbor,
sharing generously what we have,
and letting go of our hurts and fears.

As we let go of these offerings
and give them for the work of justice
in this place and beyond,
may we find peace, hope, and courage
in you, now and forever.
Amen and Amen.

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Tanaka Pack & Rev. Fregin

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Ever just beyond our reach,
the sacred calls us to new understandings of ourselves
and to new ways of embracing the world.

Ever in pursuit of us,
it challenges us to name each place we find,
each corner in which we think ourselves alone, 'Holy.'

*Ever within us,
it fills us to overflowing with a great love
so that ever amongst us,
it might be made known in this challenging world.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.

Choral Response

"What Are You Going Through"
N.E.O. Festival Chorus and Cathedral Choir

ROBYN CEE KAY JACOB

*"Attention is prayer, it presupposes faith and love. To know that this person who is
hungry and thirsty exists as much as I do, what are you going through?"*

*Hymn for the Journey

Alchemy of Healing

COLUMCILLE IRISH MELODY, arr. JOHN BELL

The courage we borrow, the courage we bring
Shall bind us in strength to the healing we sing.
The courage to face any wound that we fear
Shall bind us in beauty and bless every tear.

Bring grace and bring kindness to all that you sing,
To heal and to honour each fierce tender thing.
Each shame left unspoken may yet shine a light,
A place that seemed broken, that place can give life.

The darkness we banish, the shadow we blame
Though hidden, may help us to find our true name.
So bring all your courage that all be made whole,
Transforming your story in body and soul.

Come gather your power with good friends around.
Together we stand in the truth of this ground.
Our courage can make us, can heal and can mend,
And a wound can be sacred, any wound we transcend.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Abraham Ross, Guest Organist
Vers l'espérance — Thierry Escaich

Inside The Music

"This is the seventh year that vocalists and composers from across the globe have gathered at The Cathedral to celebrate the human voice at the N.E.O. Voice Festival. Each year we kick off the week by singing in the morning service. This is a special time for the FCCLA and N.E.O. communities to connect and share. On Friday 8/1 the N.E.O. group will premiere their ExplOratorio "Rules For Being Human," and you are all invited to attend what will be a stunning evening. The music this morning all comes from the pens of N.E.O. composers as well. Zeek's introit is the first half of his aria to the Greek mythological character Clotho. Clotho is the one of the Three Fates who spins the thread of human life. As such, she holds a mysterious place of wonder in the pantheon. To illuminate her unique role, Zeek chose a quote from T.S. Eliot's "The Love Song Of J. Alfred Prufrock." Prufrock's tale is one of suspended time. It seems to perpetually ask the question of why we might choose to be troubled in life. Zeek's undulating, and somewhat melancholic, melody opens our ears to reflection and acceptance. Jamey wrote "Connection" for the 2023 N.E.O. Festival, and is back again this year. "Connection" contains the one central phrase "are you ok?" repeated over and over again. As the voices repeat the words, they are instructed to explore varied emotional spaces. The soloist and chorus often occupy different explorations. Sometimes the chorus is in contrast to the soloist, sometimes they are a voice calling her back, and sometimes they sing together. At the end, the phrase turns from "are you ok?" to "you are ok." As this new take on the words settle, the music swells, generously energizing the sense of release that comes with it. Sam wrote "Simply Assisting God" for his mentor, Joel Krott, on Joel's 50th work anniversary as a music director at FPC Moorestown, NJ. He said that the Piet Hein text spoke to him of Joels' life in music. Hein's poem relates to the artist's experience from a distinctly untroubled place. It recognizes that the artist isn't "needed" in the cosmic order of things, but that our creative efforts in faith are welcomed in the divine cloth. Sam's lilting compound meter melodies frolic and dart around the page, a soul freed to expand into the wholeness of creation. We'll only sing the second half of Robyn's setting of Simone Weil's penetrating poem to close the service. It calls us into focus, to bring attention to the suffering, and thereby the release, of ourselves and others. On the phrase "Attention is prayer" she separates the words, each voice part singing in bell-like echo. "Listen!" the music says as it calls us to awareness. From this call, the words "faith and love" flow into our new sense of being. By the time we arrive at the question "what are you going through?" we have been greeted with reason enough to receive our needs in a broader context. We are invited to choose an untroubled path, though not without recognition of what might trouble us. Whatever we suffer with, the text says, is real. We are all worthy of notice. And we can choose how we allow potential troubles to impact us. Robyn's music comforts even as the words open potential challenges. The practice of recognizing our suffering sits at the center of compassion. If we are to be untroubled in this life, we must go through our suffering in order to find a resting place beyond it. Robyn's music ends with the lines "what are you going through" echoing in repetition alongside "as much as I do." She reminds us that in this ongoing dance for our identities, we are surrounded by others who are going through a similar experience." – Dr. David Harris